
Accent
Asian Student Union

Editor-in-Chief
Divya Bhatia

ASU Co-Heads
Divya Bhatia
Richard Zhu
Natasha Hearder
Tejas Pailla

Contributors
Divya Bhatia
Ellen Chen
Riya Goyal
Ronit Goyal
Esther Lin
Lindsey Liu
Katio Mo
Kadence Sun
Meg Vongkitbuncha
Josephine Xie
Richard Zhu

Brought to you by the Asian Student Union

Accent

Accent tells the stories of Asians and Asian Americans living in the United States. As the word “accent” means a distinctive way of pronouncing words in a certain language by putting emphasis on a particular syllable, we strive to show the diverse and distinct nature of being Asian by putting emphasis on personal stories.

Brought to you by the Asian Student Union, *Accent* invites everyone to get a glimpse of what it means to be an Asian in 21st century America. By sharing our voices, we become more resilient and powerful. Creativity is our way of empowering each other.

The Asian Student Union at St. Andrew’s School is a safe space for all students who identify as Asian. We strive to unite and empower through cultural and educational avenues.

Letter from the Heads

Dear Reader,

I have had the amazing opportunity to create and edit the fifth edition of the *Accent* Magazine. It has been my honor to put together a literary work of art to bring together our diverse identities ranging across the vast continent of Asia. Being able to read through, examine, and experience these stories has been a learning journey that has also allowed me to reflect on my own identity. The power of the various forms of art and literature presented in this magazine allow you to see how people can express themselves through many perspectives. This magazine is created to encourage individuals to immerse themselves through the strength and diversity we share through our identities.

It has also been my pleasure to serve as an ASU Co-Head for the second year during my time at St. Andrew's and I cannot wait to see what the next year will bring. From our annual ramen function to Asian Sensations to the Cultural Fair, we have grown in exceptional ways. Thank you to the seniors for being part of this group and lighting the way to a more inclusive space on campus. I would also like to appreciate the work my peers Richard, Natasha, and TJ put into this year's events and it has been my pleasure to work alongside them. This affinity space will only continue to grow with new ideas, new members, and new highlights to the year.

As you look through the 2025-2026 edition of the Accent Magazine, you should see the pride our community holds in all the endeavors we accomplish in regards to our Asian identity. With so much talent, I am proud to say that I am of Asian descent and we should be proud to proclaim it. The various depictions of our lifestyles show how we thrive in our community and in the world by being ourselves. I hope you enjoy this edition of the Accent Magazine and find pieces of those lifestyles that resonate with you!

Sincerely,
Divya Bhatia '27
Co-Head & Editor in-Chief

Dear Reader,

It has been an honour to provide and represent for Asian Student Union as a fellow co-head this year. Truthfully, I was somewhat scared to join the ASU functions as a freshman- not knowing how welcoming this community truly is. From our wins in SAISL to functions in the classroom, one can always feel the vibrance looming in the community. My freshman year self definitely would not have imagined myself later running the same community I was once hesitant to be a part of. I could not have asked for a better year with this group, or better co-heads to lead and work with. Thank you Divya, TJ, and Richard for always putting so much effort into the group and being such easy people to work with!

I hope everyone enjoys this year's edition of the Accent Magazine and appreciate all the work our fellow classmates have put into their pieces. The SAS ASU community has a lot of vibrance and culture to offer and I am so thankful everyone else can be a part of it too.

Sincerely,
Natasha Hearder '26
Co-Head

Dear Reader,

Time flies, and I almost can't believe that we have reached the end of 2025-2026. When I decided to join ASU as a freshman, I was deeply struck with both fear and relief: the fear of the uncertainty of how I will navigate myself for the next four years and the relief that I found a home, a group of people that I want to dedicate all of myself to and to serve. It has always been truly an honor for me to serve as the Co-Head of ASU for the past two years, and now, as a senior who is about to graduate, I can't reinforce this gratitude enough. ASU has taught me how to lead with empathy, with patience, with initiative, and a heart to bring individuals together. From SAISL, dumplings in gahagan, cultural fair, to AAPI performances, I hope that these memories stay within us and inspire us to keep going.

As you enjoy this year's Accent magazine, I want to recognize all the hard-work and dedication every writer, poet, and artist has put into sharing a part of themselves and their identity. Go ASU, and I can't wait to see how much more this group will do!!

Sincerely,
Richard Zhu'26
Co-Head

Dear Reader,

It has been a pleasure to serve as an Asian Student Union leader this yearIt has been an honor to serve as Co-Head of Asian Student Union this year. Being trusted with this role and contributing to a community that means so much to so many people has been a genuinely meaningful experience for me. Throughout the year, I've been consistently impressed by the energy and unity within ASU. Whether it was competing in SAISL, organizing events, or simply seeing our presence around the campus, there's a clear sense of pride and connection that defines this group. It's been rewarding to help support and build on that.

I'm also really thankful for the people I've worked with along the way. Thank you to Divya, Natasha, and Richard for your commitment, reliability, and the effort you put into making everything run smoothly. I'm looking forward to seeing ASU continue to grow and evolve in the future, and I'm grateful to have played a part in this year's chapter of the community.

Sincerely,
Tejas Pailla '27
Co-Head

Lunar New Year Chapel Talk
Kadence Sun

Layers of Identity
Ronit Goyal

Songkran
Meg Vongkitbuncha

Diwali Chapel Talk
Riya Goyal

Family Tree
Lindsey Liu

Lunar New Year Chapel Talk
Richard Zhu

A Prayer From Who Doesn't Pray
Josephine Xie

With Arts By

Divya Bhatia
Ellen Chen
Riya Goyal
Ronit Goyal
Esther Lin
Katie Mo

Lunar New Year Chapel Talk

Before St. Andrew's, every lunar new year I observed was both a celebration and the survival of the celebration.

For thousands of years, the Chinese have been fighting a mythical beast called "年," which means "year." Our ammunition consists of firecrackers and red decoration, because the monster is afraid of loud noises and the color red. When I was little, I identified more with the monster than the people. I too was terrified of loud noises and aunties dressed in red.

In China, the color red carries the symbolism of joy, fortune, and warmth. Yet "little me" cared for aesthetics more than symbolism. Red felt overwhelming and almost too bright, yet every winter, I helped my family drown our home in red. After I finished plastering couplets to the front door, my dad would put up two door gods that stared down at me menacingly. The door gods, with their gilded swords and intricate armor, protect homes from evil spirits. Then it was time to shop for firecrackers. In Chinese, firecrackers are "爆竹"—literally: exploding bamboo. My cousins rushed to the shelves of exploding bamboo, while I stayed as far away as possible. This fear of explosives, however, placed me in the monster's second nightmare: of having to interact with my aunties (another explosive force). "How was the final exam?", they would ask, while staring into my soul. When Chinese aunties explode, they lecture you on the ancient wisdom of "Good good study, day day up."

To survive all of the above, and earn some kind of livelihood, you must give new year's blessings. If you're familiar with the history of lunar new year chapel reflections, you may have heard from alumnus William Lin that new year's blessings overflow with Shakespearean poetics. I am here today to complicate his claim. The blessings are traditionally done in four-character idioms, which, on a sound level, is more similar to the percussive marching of military soldiers. Not lyrical, exactly. Still poetic. The physical etiquette of a blessing is also considered crucial. You must salute with your hand wrapped around a fist. In a blessing you are not a person—you become persona. You learn to slap the horse butt, which directly translated from Chinese, means suck-up. At last, you receive a red packet full of money. You count the number of Chairman Mao's faces printed on pink paper. This is the highlight of the lunar new year for many of my comrades. As much as I disliked the color red, I had to give this one a pass.

But red wasn't the only color I had to survive. You might think of the color white as peaceful and innocent, like the snow that drapes over our campus. In Peking opera its connotations are reversed: white face paint used to

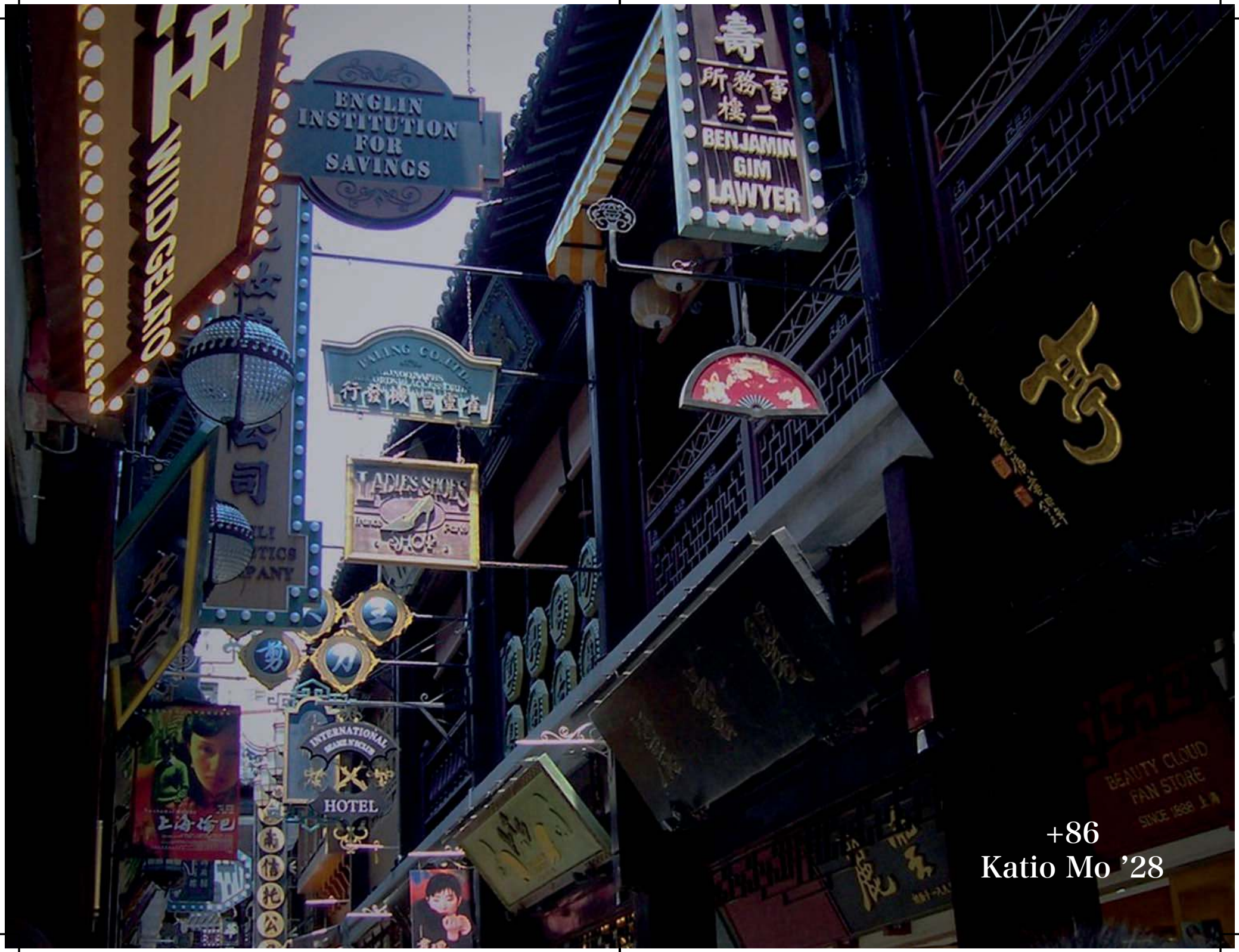
represent the more sinister characters. Black, in contrast, is associated with impartiality; blue as tenacity. My grandmother, who does not sing Peking opera, has nonetheless mastered the art of switching between the different colors of her face when needed. White is her face when I tipped over the daffodils in her glass vase (she plants them every February). The daffodils symbolize reunion, and my spilling of the vase being a breakage of unification.

Gradually, I forgave red. As I got older I could see it on grandma's face, when she meticulously skinned mandarins and set them before me on a porcelain plate. She would watch as though I were some greedy vampire, sucking out the juice from the pulpy wedges. Whenever I tried to offer her a wedge, she would refuse with a steady shake of her head, pushing the plate closer to my hand. "Too sweet," "You eat." She'd say. Now mandarins are my favorite to dream about at night when I go to sleep.

Every new year I wonder: among all these painted faces, which face is the real face? I have learned to observe and survive the performance of each face. And now, at St. Andrew's, those same faces are lit through the phone screen, a Pacific away. "Grandma is peeling your favorite mandarins!" my parents said to me on FaceTime during their New Year's Eve dinner. In the background, over the sound of the spring festival gala on TV, the shouts of my relatives were interrupted by the frequent boom of the firecrackers.

In that moment of clamor over the call, which sharply contrasted with the silence of my morning, I felt an absence loom over me. I waited for the sensation to disappear into the downdrafts of snow. Here I no longer need to survive celebration—I crave it, reach for it, for any strand of red to overwhelm the white. My family at St. Andrew's, with their own uniquely painted faces, allowed me to shorten—at least a little—the seemingly uncollapsible distance between two continents.

I still miss every painted face of my family. And most of all, the white face of my grandma, draining of color when her vase of daffodils fell from my hand. I think of the colors beneath the white, the eternal red surfacing. That was perhaps the moment when she realized she would spend the new years awaiting my homecoming.



+86
Katio Mo ’28

Layers of Identity

Ronit Goyal ’27

In the heart of two worlds, I find my place,
An Indian soul with an American twist,
I am born of a heritage rich,
With a story that has yet to unfold,

Food is a common ground,
Where sweets meet spices together,
I am born of flavors mixed and distinct,
Bridged together by two styles,

From cities to suburbs to villages,
Everything is closely tied,
I am born of an Indian American community,
With a story that has yet to unfold,

I speak in tongues, languages diverse,
In English fluency, in Hindi’s verse,
I am born of a diverse dialect,
Crafted by my surroundings,

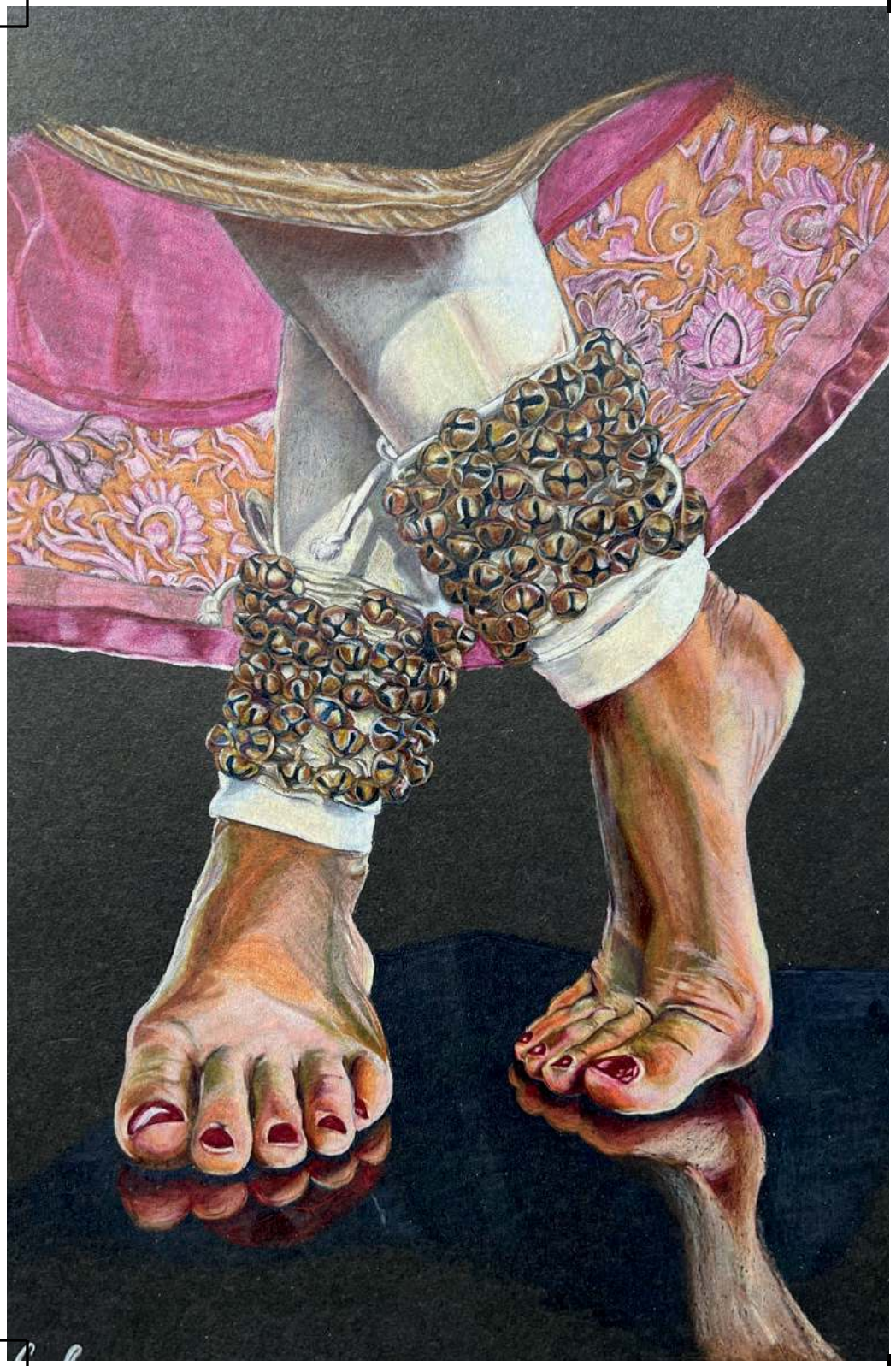
Sweet sounding music floods my ears,
While other beats unify with it,
I am born of traditional and modern music,
With a story that has yet to unfold,

Traveling across India and America for adventure,
Looking through with two lenses,
I am born of journey through my homelands,
Each one giving something new,

I am the dreams of my parents’ eyes,
The hopes they carried across their life,
I am born of sacrifice and struggle,
With a story that has yet to unfold,

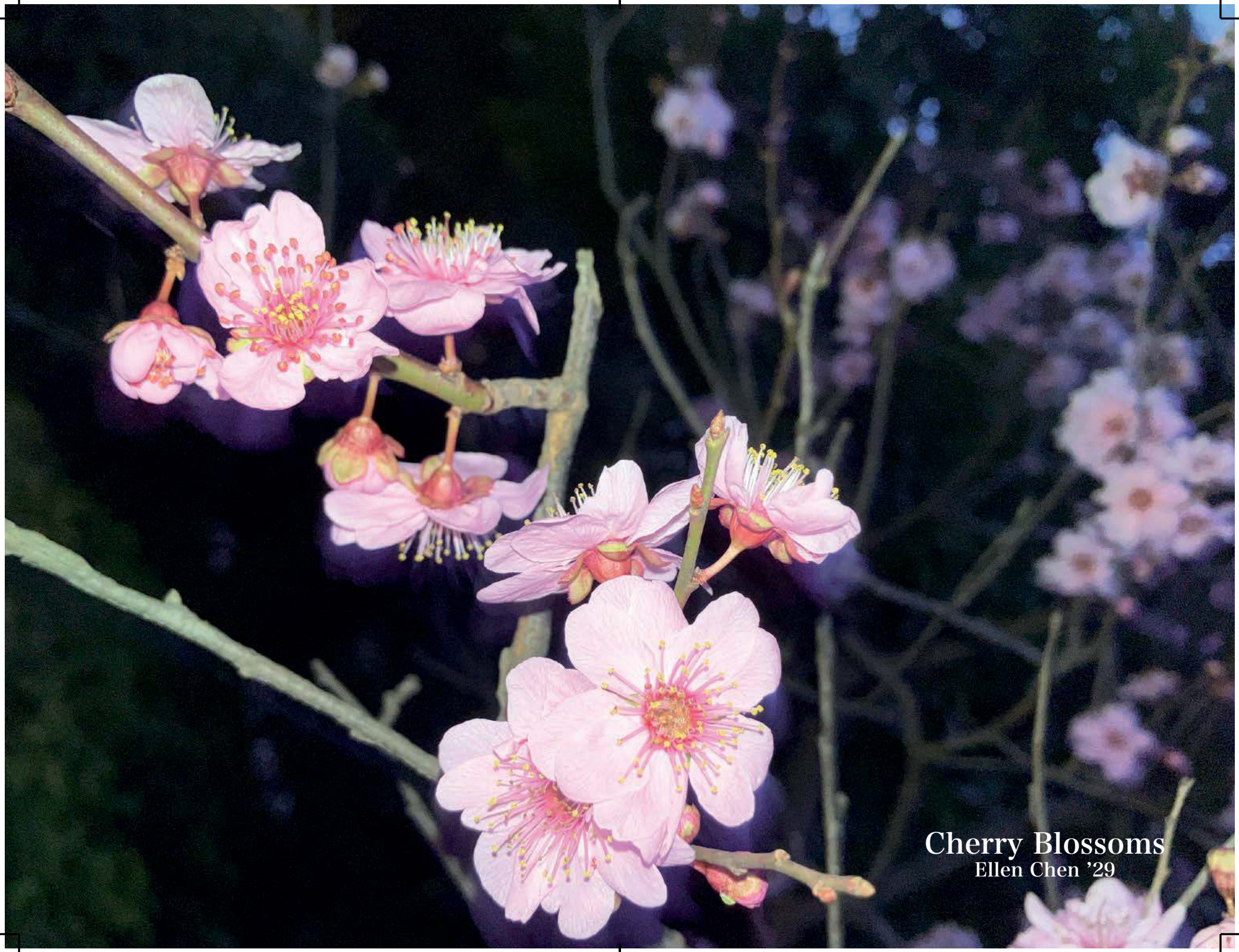
I am Indian, I am American, I am both and more,
A tapestry of cultures, intricately weaved,
I am born of the fusion of identities,
Identities that have made me whole,

So let me embrace these sides of me,
Let me weave my story in every line,
For in the journey of self-discovery,
I see the beauty of being an Indian American.



My Pulse Bound in Brass

Riya Goyal ’27



Cherry Blossoms
Ellen Chen ’29

Songkran

Meg Vongskitbuncha ’29

Songkran, held from April 13th - 15th, is the Thai celebration of the New-Year. Involving nationwide water fights, pouring water on someone symbolizes good luck and new beginnings.

The clock strikes midnight on April 13th,
And for the first time,
I’ve never felt farther away.
The clock strikes midnight on April 13th,
And I know it’s Songkran,
But for me, it’s a regular day.
The sun rises on April 13th,
And I don’t wake up to piercing cold,
And piles of water all in my way.
The sun rises on April 13th,
And I hear echoes of laughing
As my friends find someone new to betray,
Water gun in one hand, buckets of blessings in the other,
Good luck emerging.
The sun shines down on April 13th,
And I run to get to class,
Not away from family, friends, or even strangers
Chasing me through the grass.
The sun shines through my window on April 13th,
And I look at my friend’s pictures on my phone,
The lights, the color, the slides, the castles,
The malls, the heat, the food, the people
And their memories remind me of my own.
I remember splashing everyone everywhere all the time,
in school, in the street, in the city, in my neighborhood–
I also remember the flower garlands,
With Jasmine, Lotus, Marigold, and Ratchapruek.
And for our elders, we made them as best as we could.
I remember how important Songkran is to my culture,
To my family, to my character,
To my childhood.
So when the sun sets on April 13th,
And the 14th and 15th pass by,
I remember the magic
Of being part of the chaos and community all engaged in water play.
I remember the love
At the family gatherings, everyone there to stay.
And I most of all remember the joy,
the battle, the festival, and the celebration
That was Songkran.



Flute Among the Four Gentlemen

Esther Lin ’29

Flute Among the Four Gentlemen

Description by Esther Lin ’29

Of the “Four Gentlemen” in Chinese art and philosophy—plum (梅), orchid, bamboo (竹), and chrysanthemum (菊)—each symbolizes a virtue or characteristic. The plum blossom (top left) blooms in late winter, and it symbolizes perseverance and hope; The orchid (on the hair) grows in secluded places, and stands for quiet dignity; The bamboo (bottom left) bends in storms but never breaks, and represents an open mind and humility; and the chrysanthemum (bottom right) blooms after all other flowers have fallen, and signifies endurance and the courage to age with grace.



Golden Harmony

Esther Lin ’29

Diwali Chapel Talk

Riya Goyal '27

My mom is very fond of flowers. If you walk into my house, there will always be purple and white orchids in the corner and a bouquet of orangish pink roses. There will be the money plant in the other corner, and other plants that I don't know the names of. This same vibrancy is amplified in ten folds during Diwali. For as long as I can remember, Diwali in my family has been full of color and radiance. This means my mom lighting diyas around the house, my dad wrapping extravagant trays of sweets that I would deliver to friends, the exterior and interior of the house covered in lights, making a rangoli while Ronit hovers over my shoulder, and my grandfather, whom I call nana, always calling to ask what new dresses he could send me that year. He would always insist I choose something bright and sparkly: pink, yellow, blue, anything but plain.

I was always most spoiled by my nana. After all, I was born on the first day that marks the start of Diwali, Dhanteras, an auspicious day about wealth and prosperity in which new purchases of gold or silver are made. Essentially, it feels like being spoiled by my grandfather was kind of written in my horoscope. My mom and I always argue about who he loves more. She likes to think it's her, but we all know the truth, and my grandfather could never deny it. Whenever we visited my grandparents in Mumbai, the house was always somehow full of my favorite foods and sweets, and the first day of our trip would be full of shopping, something that all three generations of women, starting from my grandmother to my mom to me, all enjoyed to the max. My mom and my nani would barter with my nana for money to go shopping. He was a businessman, so you know he didn't mess around. They would only manage a little bit, but the minute I walked in, my mom and nani used his favoritism towards me to double and capitalize on our budget. We had so much fun every time – him taking us to clothing and jewelry shops around the city, and I cherished every minute we would spend time together. Ronit and I always used to beg him to go to our favorite restaurant called Orchid, where we would feel fancy drinking the incredible tomato soup and trying all the exotic dishes that only restaurants in India seem to do right. He would take us on long drives next to the Arabian Sea to see the lighted Chatrapati Shivaji Terminal, the beautiful bridge over the sea, Queen's necklace (which are the street lights that wrap around Marine Drive, the famous promenade in Mumbai), and we would go to my favorite ice cream place. To end the night, we would always come home to watch TV together and play cards before he would fall asleep. All these memories stayed with me throughout the school year, knowing that I could always give him a call from here, and it wouldn't be long until it was summer and we would be flying to Mumbai again to recreate these memories. My nana has always been my favorite person in this world, and there is truly no one that I know that loves me as much as him. Giving and

generosity were simply in his nature.

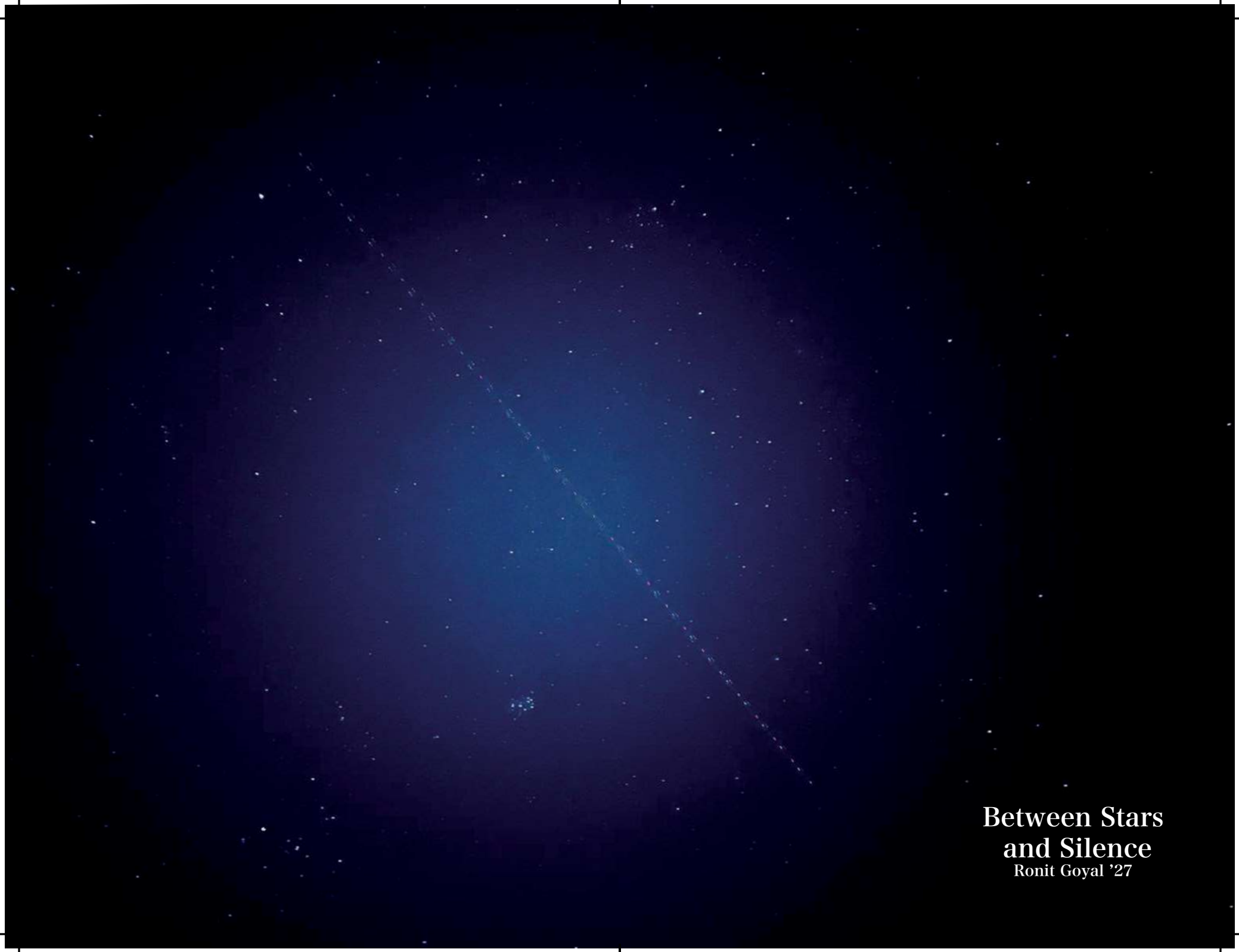
But this year feels different. August 15, 2025. Two weeks before I was leaving to come to school. Everything suddenly went from ordinary to chaotic, and I stood right there in the mess of it all, knowing that there will now forever be a before and an after. There was no goodbye, just an absence, sudden, abrupt, and louder than any voice could be. I never knew how time slipped, and in the spots where there were usually my mom's colored flowers, there now stood white and blue. I never thought that my nana's scolding on the phone was the last time I would be scolded by him. I never knew that the last time he hung up before I could say I love you was the last time I would laugh at his innocence. I never thought that our last goodbye on the phone meant goodbye forever.

Now my favorite time of the year has come around. Diwali is here, but my nana's passing makes it hard to imagine the festival as the same. I never received his annual phone call with wishes and blessings for Diwali and the Hindu New Year. It feels like every diya has been blown out, and the alleged "festival of lights" is now dark. One of my favorite holidays of the year that used to be filled with color now feels quieter. When I think of him, all I seem to envision is white – the color of mourning and loss in my culture.

Every story with him that I reminisce over feels so real, until I remember that now it is all just a collection of memories. Grief is a feeling that cannot be healed. It is a scar that even time cannot erase. But, I am learning to live with it and become comfortable with its discomfort. And amidst learning to find closure, I have come to realize that even white carries light within it. After all, it's what happens when every color comes together. Perhaps, that is the lesson of this year's Diwali for me: that even in loss, love does not disappear. It just changes form. On the days when I find myself missing him the most, I remember how he loved me. On the days where grief shows up when I put on the watch he gave me, when I Facetime my mom and see her sitting in his office chair, when I listen to a song, when I paint his portrait, and when I sit in silence, I remember how he loved me. For all of you that have lost a loved one or miss a family member a little extra on special occasions, remember how they loved you and give yourself that same love. On those days you miss them most, love yourself as they loved you.

After chapel, when we will release lanterns on Noxontown pond, I will be lighting one for my grandfather. For his laughter, his kindness, and for the light he brought into my life. I invite you all to think of someone you love unconditionally, whether they are near or far, as you release yours. Because when you set aside the mythological meaning and celebration, Diwali, at its heart, is about family and love. It is about carrying the light of those connections forward. So even though this Diwali looks a little different for me, I know my grandfather's light is still here, in memory, in gratitude, and in every lantern that floats across the water tonight.

I wish you all a very Happy Diwali, and may you find light, even in the darkness, and I hope that the festival brings you endless love, laughter, and light. Thank you.



Between Stars and Silence

Ronit Goyal '27

Family Tree

Lindsey Liu ’28

To my ancestors:
The glass and wooden frame contain your austere love.
Contempt leaks out of the coal-black peas that are your eyes.
As I extrapolate your thoughts,
They gnaw at the eroding black and white.

The photo of you two hang, my great-grandmother and great-grandfather,
Like stationary shots of waning moons
Over my grandparents’ living room;
And your chalky eyes fixate on me like I am your prey.

To my grandpa:
Your wilted hands comb through the chicken skin,
Plucking out all the hairs; they have minds of their own.
The biting red wiggles into the crevices in your fingernails.
The stench remains when you cook and brush my hair.

To my mother:
You emerged out of the pillars of dirt that you were raised on, coated in grime.
Thank you for your grit.



Inherited Rythym

Divya Bhatia ’27

Lunar New Year Chapel Talk

Richard Zhu '26

Throughout the past two years at St. Andrew's, I have contributed to many chapels through singing, but I never really got the chance to share with you my story about where I came from and who I was growing up through words. Several times when I start speaking in Chinese, people would drop their jaws, saying, "I don't know you can do that". Therefore, because the Chinese new year is the time for families to come together, I want to use this opportunity to remind myself and everyone about their sense of home, and how my cultural identity shaped me along the way.

I had never lived in another place before I arrived in Delaware. Hangzhou, a south-eastern city of China along the coast that has only started to get renowned for the past decade, has been my home for as long as I can remember. Tall buildings, subway constructions, colored lights, and shopping malls made up my city. I truly loved being an urban kid, and in my opinion, was the best; with the bustling streets during the day, the gorgeous neon lights after sundown, Hangzhou never fails to impress me with its beauty.

Speaking of my name, Richard is in fact, not my first name. My birth name is 朱家禾 (Zhu Jiahe), with my last name originating from Ming dynasty and my first name with the literal meaning "home and harvest." I used to feel very disconnected to my name, and I always complained to my mom, "who's name is like that?" However, as I grew older, I thanked my parents for choosing such a special name, for the name extends beyond its literal meaning. Home implies stability, and harvest means hardwork; It was not until years later that I realized my name is just like who I am right now, always wanting for the best and wanting to give the best. Subconsciously, my name has guided me as I grow, alongside with other cultural values like loyalty, responsibility and empathy that my mom taught me over and over, with me sitting there nodding my head taking them in, and sort of pretending that I understood all of them.

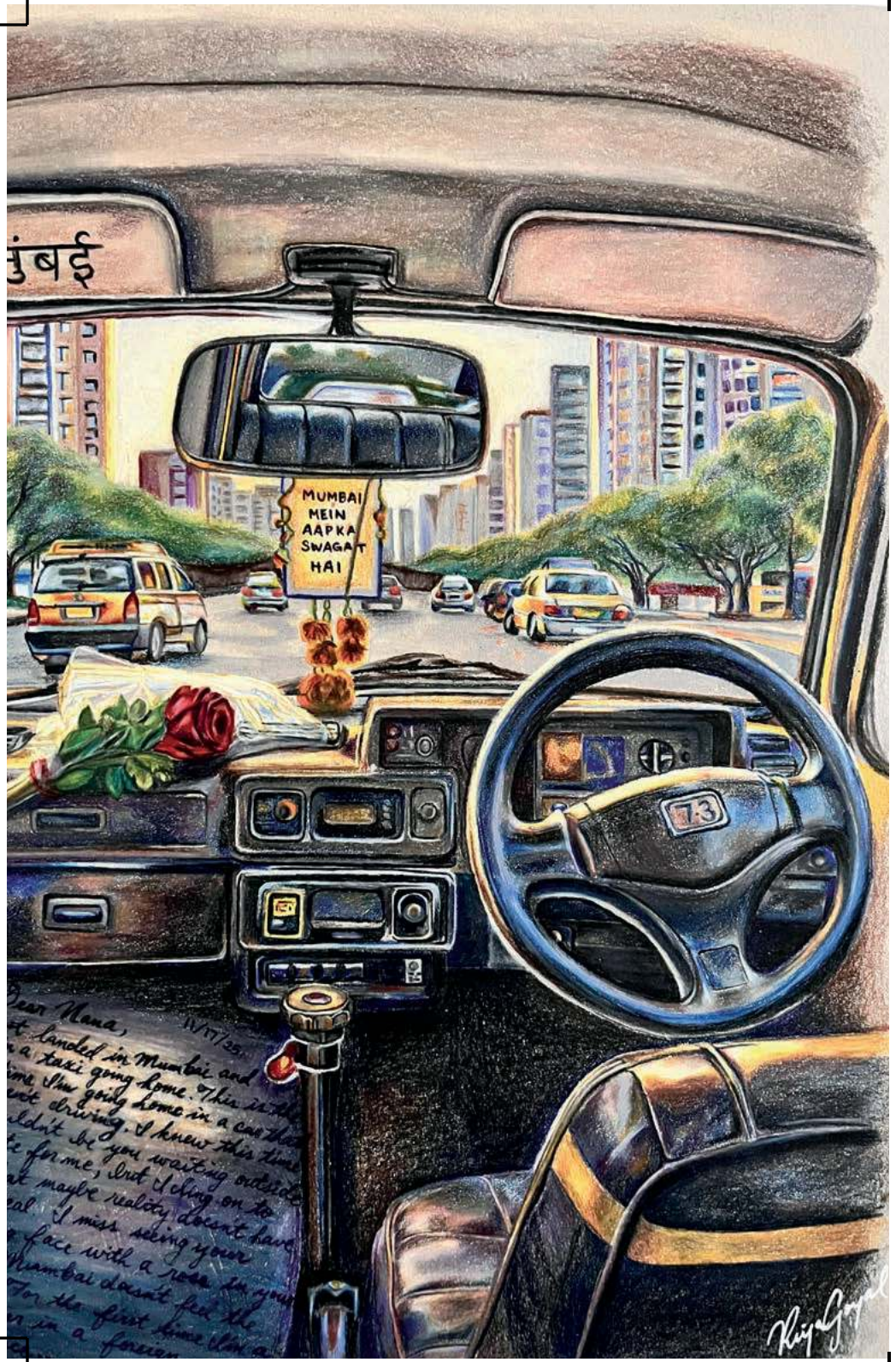
I grew up going to a regular public school like all other kids, so I barely came across English until much later, at sixth grade, at the age of eleven. The learning environment developed my discipline and the idea of constantly pushing myself. With so many other people around me who I viewed as better, it was not uncommon for me to try everything until I feel like it's close to perfect. Along with my awakening in learning disciplines, I also joined a local choir near my house, and I have been singing ever since. We sang Chinese songs, and I was passionate about it. My love for Chinese pop has never changed, even with the thousands of English and other language songs on my "recently played" page. For my say, Chinese songs massively influenced my singing because there is a part of me that is

always so sensitive, so emotional, and so fluid, that I found it hard to describe. Now, singing in English is no longer unfamiliar for me, in fact, it has become something I have to do all the time. However, everytime I perform for this chapel in my own language, it is a sense of home and freedom that I am being called to, that I drop the need to care for the words and the grammar and, but only let that beam of musicality and my own language shine to its brightest.

Fast forward in time, I was fourteen when I made up my mind to study abroad. Among the sea of schools I applied to, St. Andrew's chose me, and gladly, I chose St. Andrew's as well. However, having not seen the campus for once or been to the U.S, I was honestly just a reckless kid who decided to travel away from home to pursue the independence and the challenge he wanted.

Then came the first few weeks of my freshman year. I was impressed by the gorgeous lake and the lush forests, and I was more excited than ever to start a new adventure. However, I was not used to saying "Hi" in the corridors, speaking without having to raise hands in a classroom, greeting each other in ways that I never knew existed, and having to live in a place that is the loudest I have ever heard in my entire life - founders dorm, well, in a good way. To be honest, I was genuinely scared for the first two weeks. I recall a conversation with Mr. Kwon during the first month of school, when he wanted to take international students to Chipotle. The first sentence I said to him was, "what is Chipotle''. Fortunately, I got explained afterwards. Though I quickly bonded with many through my music and other things, and adapted to the new environment, I cannot help but find myself feeling more comfortable around other students of my same race, who speak the same language, who share a common experience. I learned to accept this feeling, for it is a way of trying to reconcile between my identity and this new place, a way of knowing that it is just another challenge I have to take. As time progressed, I also learned that my identity is actually a source of fortune. For example, I would never think about performing for affinity chapels, or sharing a reflection, like I do right now.

From Hangzhou to Middletown, Delaware, I am able to call St. Andrew's my second home. But, for those who still feel shy or scared of sharing about who they are, I feel that way too. However, there is no reason to be afraid to share your most authentic self when we recall our stories, our families, our languages, our favorite festivals, and our favorite food. We were born with a gift, and we have already come this far, to be ready to share our courage and determination to the world, that we are here, and will always be here. Thank you.



The Seat You Still Fill

Riya Goyal '27

A Prayer from who doesn't Pray

Josephine Xie '27

I say this as someone who never believed
in heavens layered like old maps,
nor in souls drifting from body to body
like weather patterns.
I say this with the blunt honesty
of a mind that trusts only what I can touch:
I am an atheist—
and yet here I am, whispering a prayer.

Five years ago—
Christmas hour, lights still glowing.
My phone rang like an omen
from twelve time zones away.
My mother's voice trembled
in a way I didn't recognize,
and she handed me the phone
as if it were something burning.

On the other end,
his breath was uneven,
thin as thread pulled too far—
my great-grandfather,
the quiet center of a house
that smelled of tea leaves and sandalwood,
a Buddhist with palms folded
like a pair of resting wings.

I had only a minute—
sixty seconds rattling
like loose coins in my chest.
I didn't know what to say.
I was a child,
unpracticed in last words.
"Hi, Grandpa," I whispered,
as if volume itself could hurt him.

He told me to study hard,
to be kind,
to take care of my parents.
His voice, like calligraphy on rice paper
paused between each sentence,
searching for somewhere to settle.
I didn't know
he was already leaving.

When the line went dead
so sudden it felt intentional.
I stared at the Christmas lights,
each bulb a small, distant star,
and felt something in me collapse
into a shape I still cannot name.

I did not pray then.
I didn't know how.
I believed only in distance
like oceans and years,
the cruelty of being far
when it matters most.

He believed each life
was a doorway to another,
that endings only change their clothes.
I didn't believe him.
I trusted nothing
I couldn't carry in my hands.

But grief is a strange alchemist.
It melts certainty, bends logic,
until even a skeptic
stands barefoot in the dark
of their own heart,
hoping for impossible things.

Now, years later,
when memory sits beside me
like an old friend,
I find myself bargaining
with the universe:
a place I once thought empty,
asking it,
if only for him,
to be more.

I whispered,
Let reincarnation be real.
Let him be wandering somewhere,
light-footed, unharmed.
Let him be a child laughing
beneath an osmanthus tree,
an old man lifting steam from tea,
a crane riding slow circles
above a river.

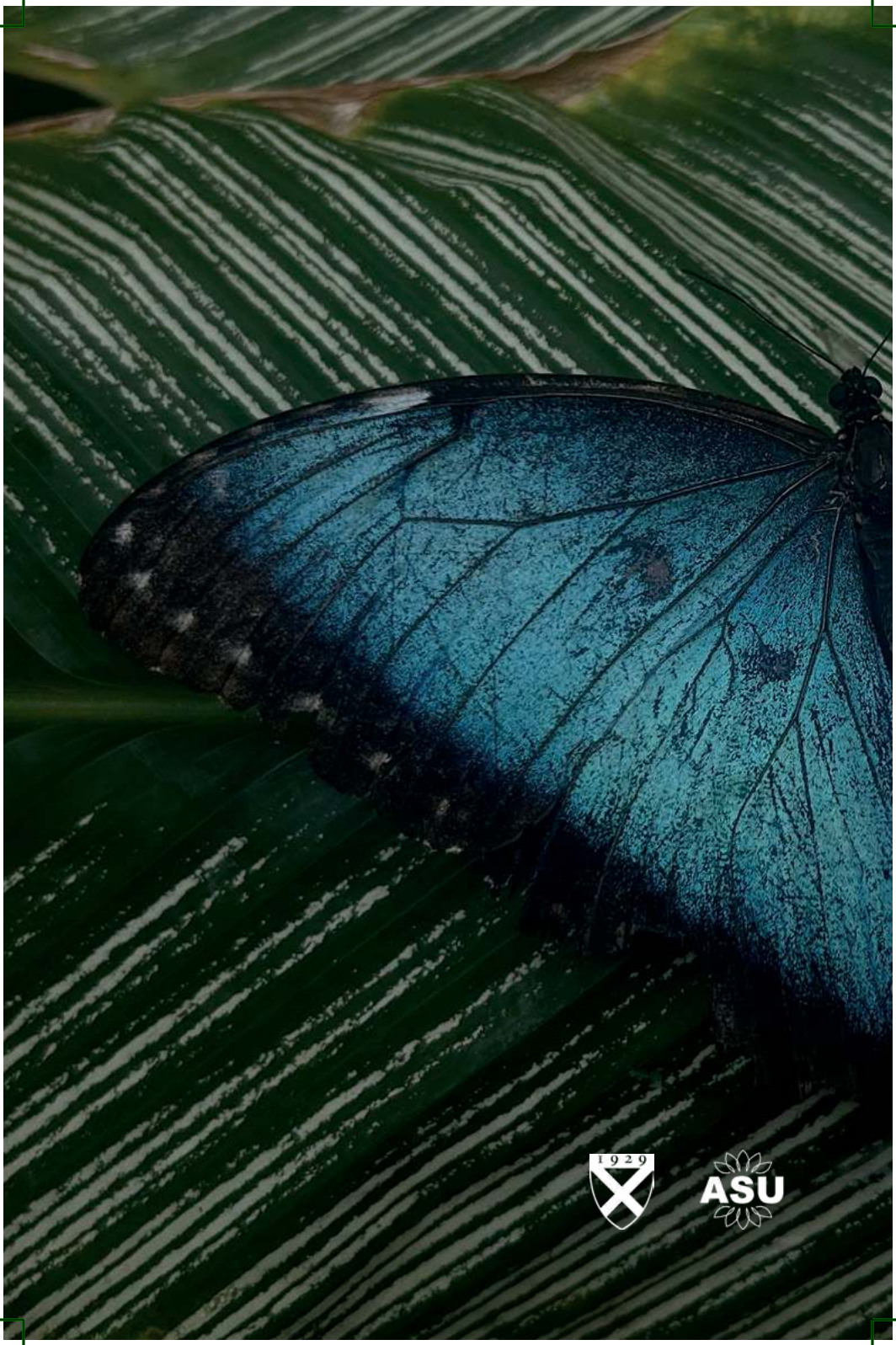
And if none of that is true—
if there is only the clean silence
after a life well lived—
then hear this,
my first and maybe only prayer:
let the part of him I loved
move forward somehow,
even if only as memory,
even if only as me.

And if nothing waits beyond this life,
no return, no shining doorway,
let this be enough:
that I miss him.
That love can hurt
and remain in love.
That grief can soften
instead of swallowing.
That I carry him forward
in ordinary ways:
in how I speak,
how I choose gentleness,
how I still wish
for more time.

I don't believe in miracles.
But I believe in this ache
and in the way it proves
that he mattered.

Special thanks to:
Communications

Cover Photo by:
Ronit Goyal


1929
ASU